

INTERVIEW SKILLS

- ✓ *“The Interviewer’s job is to find a reason to turn you down; your job is not to provide that reason” –John Laferve 55*
- ✓ The word interview comes from Latin and middle French words meaning to “see between” or “see each other”.
- ✓ When we normally think of an interview, we think a setting in which an employer tries to size up an applicant for a job.



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- ✓ An interview is a procedure designed to obtain information from a person's through oral response to oral inquiries.
- ✓ It is a systematic private formal meeting between two sides (interviewer & interviewee) in which a person enters deeply into the life of another, even a stranger and bring out needed information through questions and answers.
- ✓ Perhaps the most important key to a successful interview is *to be well-prepared for it and to have some knowledge of what to expect.*



Types of Interviews

- There are many types of interviews that an organisation can arrange depending on the objectives.
- Some important types of interviews are stated below:

(i) Informational Interview

- Is a kind of interview whose major purpose is to obtain *specific information* from the interviewee.
- Informational interview is used in many domains of information search.
- Informational interview constitutes a common research tool, especially in social sciences research project.



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- ✓ It also include radio, television and newspaper interview among public figures such as politicians, religious leaders, sports people, researchers and artists

(ii) Counseling interviews

- This may be held to find out what is troubling the students, sports people, workers or any other person to the extent that he/she fails to perform or work properly.
- It is normally done by people with special training such as the psychologists



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(iii) Job interviews

- Is an interactive dialogue based on questions and answers that are set between the job provider and the job seeker to elicit detailed information from both parties in order to find out and assess the suitability of each party to the other in the provision, acquisition and execution of the job.



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Types of job interview

- Job interviews are categorised into two types; pre-job interviews and in-job interview.

(a) In-job interview

- This deals with different interviews held within an organisation while the employee is in the job already.
- Precisely, in job interviews have nothing to do with passing in or obtaining new employees instead are conducted between the available employers and employees in the organisation in order to review the progress of the interviewees



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- In job interview may result to the following:
 - ✓ Change of an employee's position/responsibilities (recategorisation).
 - ✓ Promotion of an employee to a senior position.
 - ✓ Termination of the employee from job
 - ✓ Warning to the employee for the indiscipline behaviour
 - ✓ Signing a new or reviewing available job contract



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Pre – job interview

- ❖ Is any job interview held before a job application is accepted for recruitment into the job applied for.
- ❖ In organisations where the hiring of a new employee involves different pre-job interview, the interviews are arranged for the purpose of selection of the new employees



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Pre – Job Interviews Rules and Tips for Job Seekers

- These rules and tips will help job-seekers to maximize potential employment opportunities
- There is no way to predict what an interview holds, but by following these important rules you will feel less anxious and will be ready to positively present yourself



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- It is important to appear confident and cool for the interview. One way to do that is to be prepared to the best of your ability

(i) Researching the employer/organisation

- Explore the company before the interview, learn as much as possible about its services, products, customers, stake holders and competitors.
- This will give you an edge in understanding and addressing the company's needs.
- Know how you can help the company and prepare questions to ask the interviewer about the company.



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- The more you know about the company and what it stands for, the better chance you have of selling yourself in the interview
- You also should find out about the company's structure and culture to gain insight into your potential happiness on the job.
- Know the company's history/evolution, mission, vision and where is located

(ii) Be positive/optimistic

- Employers do not want to hear a list of excuses or bad feelings about a negative experience.



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- If you are asked about a low grade, a sudden job change or a weakness in your background, don't be defensive.
- Focus instead on the facts (briefly) and emphasize what you learned from the experience.
- Never comment negatively about your former employer.

(iii) Personality

- Select what to wear to the interview.
- Depending on the industry and position, get out your best interview clothes and check them over for spots and wrinkles.



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- Above all, dress for confidence. If you feel good, others will respond to you accordingly.
- Personality wins a day!

(iv) Be Prepared

- Be prepared to market your skills and experiences as they relate to the job described.
- Work at positioning yourself in the mind of the employer as a person with a particular set of skills and attributes.
- Work to describe your qualifications appropriately



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- You may bring along a portfolio containing original documents such as certificates and CV
- A list of questions the interviewee expects to ask at the end of the interview when given chance.
- Make sure you turn off your phone before entering the room

(v) Punctuality

- The first impression matters a lot
- Arriving late creates a bad first impression and may doom your chances.



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- ✓ Allow extra time to arrive early in the area, taking into consideration factors like getting lost, vehicle break down, traffic jam etc.
- By the same token arriving too early confuses the employer and creates an awkward situation
- Plan to enter the building 10 to 15 minutes before the interview.
Be wise!

(vi) **Show Enthusiasm/interest**

- A firm handshake and plenty of eye contact demonstrate confidence.
- Speak clearly in a confident voice, even though you may feel



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- Be yourself. Don't be afraid of short pauses. You may need a few seconds to formulate an answer.

(vii) Listen/ be attentive

- One of the most neglected interview skill is listening
- Be careful for both verbal and non-verbal communication.
- Sometimes what is not said is just as important as what is said



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(viii) **Answer the Question Asked**

- Make sure you understand what is being asked, and get further clarification if you are unsure.
- Give specific examples that highlight your successes and uniqueness.

(ix) **If provided breakfast/lunch**

- Often social skills are part of the hiring decision
- In many career fields, the breakfast or lunch included during the interview day does not only mean employer's hospitality, but also a significant part of the interview process.
- Brush up on your table manners and ability to observe protocol carry.



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(x) Ask Questions

- At the end of most interviews, you will be given a chance to ask questions
- The questions you ask indicate your interest in the company or job.
- Bring list of questions you would like to get answers
- The questions may be:
 - i) How soon will the decision for this position be made?
 - ii) Which medium will be used for feedback?
 - iii) What are the opportunities for advancement in your organisation?



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- iv) What are the criteria for promotion in your organisation?
- v) Does the organisation provide additional education for employees who want to develop their skills?
- vi) Are there any fringe benefits provided by your organisation to employees?
- Thank the interviewers for short listing you among the interviewees.
- Leave with a warm smile and you may handshake if entertained by the interviewers.
- Let them remember and consider you special/unique applicant.



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(xi) Follow up

- Whether it's through email or other means, the interview follow up is one more chance to remind the interviewer of all the valuable traits you bring to the job and company.
- Don't miss this last chance to market yourself.
- Follow up the interview with a thank you letter
- Employers regard this signal as evidence of your attention to detail, as well as an indication of your passion in the position.



How to Evaluate Job Offers

- ▶ To avoid dilemma, it's better to start your job search with a list of what you want in the new job.
- ▶ Once you begin to receive offers, you can compare the jobs to your list to see which one best fits your criteria/priorities, and then choose.



(i) Think about More than Money

- Don't just judge the job on the salary basis.
- This is one of the most common mistakes job seekers make.
- It is true you need to be able to pay your bills and sustain your lifestyle, but taking a job purely based on a larger paycheck can set you up for failure and disappointment.
- Consider how you connect with the boss, fellow workers, network etc.



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(ii) Look at the company's culture long-term satisfaction

- Consider the environment and culture of the organization as the most important part of the decision.
- Is it a place where you can advance your skills and profession?
- If you are not happy at the organization, salary is not going to matter, and you most likely will not perform to the best of your ability.
- Focus on your future.



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(iii) Job Security

- Younger employees may not need to worry about job security as much as someone nearing retirement.
- But everyone should think about this before accepting an offer.
- Look up the company's competitors and see how they are doing.
- Check news articles for updates on the growth or decline of a company.
- Think of health insurance, sick leave, retirement pension and other fringe benefits



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(iv) Location

- This expression may seem trite, but it's true.
- Location is everything.
- Consider public transportation options between your home and prospective workplace.
- Taking public transportation between home and work helps reduce the time you spend in traffic and the money you waste on fare or petrol.



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(v) Working Condition/ Environment

- Having physical working conditions that are safe
- Not injurious to health, not stressful, and even comfortable.
- Extra services such as gyms, day care centres, houses, access to loans etc.



Some of the Qualities most Employers Demand

- i) Effective communication- employers need candidates with ability to get on with a wide range of people.
- ii) Team working- Candidates with abilities to mobilize people and enhance working as a group in accomplishing the organizational goals.
- iii) IT Skills – Candidates who are computer literates.
- iv) Flexibility- Candidates who are multipurpose i.e. who can perform a variety of tasks to achieve a common organizational goal.
- v) Problem solving- Candidate who can identify problems and look for their solutions.
- vi) Quick learning- Employee who can learn and understand faster thus able to take new tasks in the organization.



Some of the Common Interview Questions

- i) What are your future career plans?
- ii) Do you consider your education valuable? Why?
- iii) What do you consider to be your strengths and weaknesses?
- iv) Why did you choose your particular career?
- v) What qualifications do you have that make you feel you would be successful in your field?
- vi) What do you think determines a person's progress in any organisation?
- vii) What personal characteristics are necessary for success in your chosen field?

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- viii) Do you prefer working with others or by yourself?
- ix) What do you know about opportunities in the field in which you are trained?
- x) What do you expect to be doing in five, ten or fifteen years?
- xi) What are the disadvantages of your chosen field?
- xii) Do you feel you have received a good general training?
- xiii) Have you ever had any difficulty getting along with fellow students and teacher? How did you overcome the situation?



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xiv) What jobs have you held? How were they obtained, and why did you leave?

xv) What jobs have you enjoyed most? Least? Why?

xvi) Have you ever trained anyone to do a job?

xvii) What do you know about our organization and why do you think you might like to work for it?

xviii) What interests you about our product or service?

xix) What salary do you expect on this job?

xx) Is it an effort for you to be tolerant of persons with a background and interest different from your own?



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xxi) What are your own special abilities? How can they help to accomplish the organizational goals?

xxii) Which area(s) of the field interests you most? Why?

xxiii) What experience related to this position have you had?

xxiv) How would you summarize your overall knowledge and skills in the field? (Mention strengths and areas of special interest.)

What is your educational background? (Start from secondary to tertiary level not kindergarten)

xxv) Which race, sex, are you most comfortable to work with?

